



2026 WNBA FREE-AGENT MARKET

HIGH-END VALUE, MARKET SIGNALS & ROSTER IMPLICATIONS

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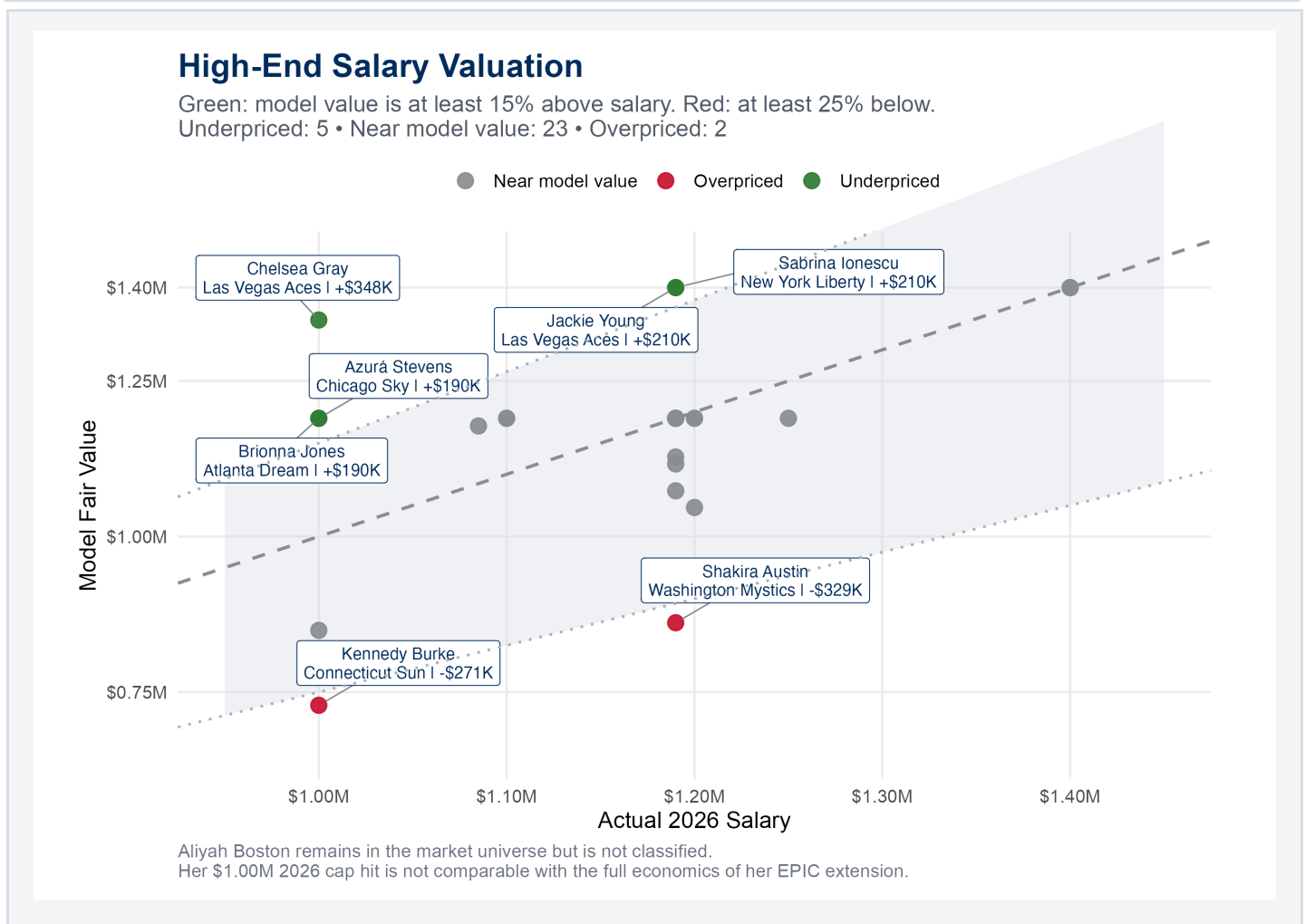
EXECUTIVE READ

Using listed 2026 salary as the only consistent public proxy for AAV, the high-end market compressed very different players into the same price point: 14 of 31 received the \$1.19M standard maximum. A CBA-aware model surfaced five underpriced and two overpriced signals. Chelsea Gray and Sabrina Ionescu were the featured undervalued cases; Kennedy Burke and Shakira Austin were the clearest risk-adjusted overvaluation flags. Playmaking and winning pedigree were discounted most, while scoring pressure alone was roughly neutral. Going forward, teams should price players against attainable salary tiers and use term, guarantees and incentives to manage health and role-growth risk.

01 MARKET AT A GLANCE SALARY & VALUE

67% PRICED NEAR FAIR VALUE 2/3 of comparable salaries were within $\pm 10\%$ of the model estimate	45% PRICED AT THE SAME LEVEL 14 players received exactly \$1.19M - standard maximum	7 CBA-AWARE PRICING SIGNALS 5 underpriced & 2 overpriced after eligibility caps
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02 WHO WAS PAID ABOVE OR BELOW FAIR VALUE? VISUAL 01



03 HOW TO READ THE MARKET METHOD + SIGNALS

METHODOLOGY

The model estimated 2026 market value from 2023–25 performance, role, availability, age, trajectory, team success, playoff experience, and honors. It was trained on 133 veterans using repeated eight-fold cross-validation. Fair value is capped at each player's attainable \$1.19M or \$1.40M level; +15% flags a CBA-constrained bargain and -25% a strong overpay.

MODEL TYPE: elastic-net/XGBoost • MAE: \$158K

THREE MARKET SIGNALS

01 SALARY COMPRESSION Nearly half of the high-end group received the same \$1.19M maximum despite different roles, production, and resumes.

02 ELIGIBILITY CHANGES VALUE Player-specific CBA ceilings separated attainable bargains from impossible model upside.

03 PLAYMAKING & WINNING Playmaking and winning-pedigree profiles produced the largest remaining market discounts after CBA eligibility was applied.



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PAGE 2 / VALUE CASES

04 PLAYER VALUE CASES 2 UNDER • 2 OVER

UNDERVALUED 01

CHELSEA GRAY



ACTUAL
\$1.00M

FAIR VALUE
\$1.35M

VALUE GAP
+\$348K

BASKETBALL CASE

Gray remained an elite organizer in a winning context, producing 6.7 assists per 36 on 56.6% true shooting while her teams won 70% of their games from 2023-25. With five seasons in Las Vegas and a qualifying All-WNBA selection, she was supermax eligible; her \$1.00M salary represented a 26% model discount even after accounting for age and contract-term risk.

6.7 AST/36 • 56.6% TS • 70% TEAM WIN RATE

UNDERVALUED 02

SABRINA IONESCU



ACTUAL
\$1.19M

FAIR VALUE
\$1.40M

VALUE GAP
+\$210K

BASKETBALL CASE

Ionescu combined high-volume scoring and playmaking, producing 20.5 points and 6.6 assists per 36 while carrying a 26.4% usage rate from 2023-25 as New York won 68% of its games. Six Liberty seasons and three straight All-WNBA Second Team selections made her supermax eligible, yet her salary was \$210K below her \$1.40M capped fair value.

20.5 PTS/36 • 6.6 AST/36 • 26.4% USG

OVERVALUED 01

KENNEDY BURKE



ACTUAL
\$1.00M

FAIR VALUE
\$0.73M

VALUE GAP
-\$271K

BASKETBALL CASE

The \$1.00M salary priced in a larger role than Burke's pre-signing record supported. From 2023–25, she was efficient but averaged 19.3 minutes, started 21% of games, and scored 12.7 points per 36. That profile fit a rotation wing; the contract projected starter-level workload and production she had not yet shown.

19.3 MPG • 21% START RATE • 12.7 PTS/36

OVERVALUED 02

SHAKIRA AUSTIN



ACTUAL
\$1.19M

FAIR VALUE
\$0.86M

VALUE GAP
-\$329K

BASKETBALL CASE

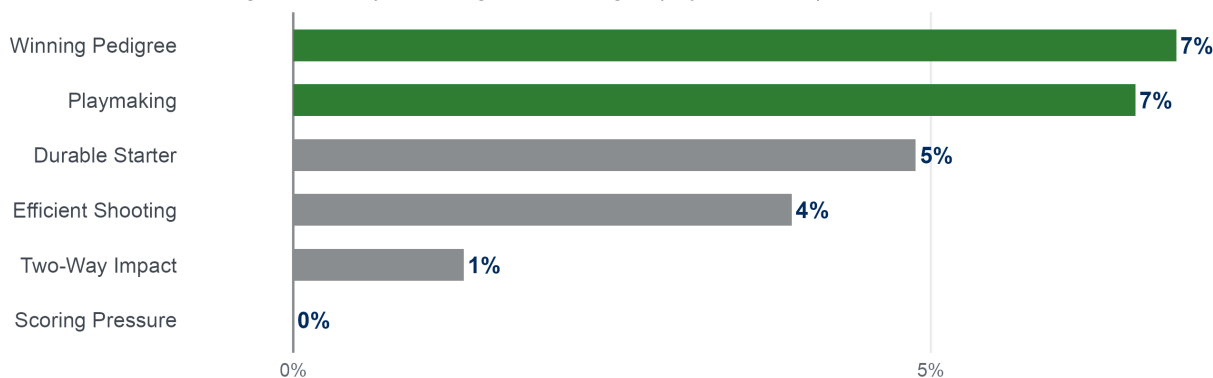
Austin's standard-max salary reflected clear interior upside, but her pre-signing profile carried availability and decision-making risk: 69 games in three seasons, 50.6% true shooting, and a 0.67 assist-to-turnover ratio ranking in the 3rd percentile among 133 veterans. Her improved 2026 play makes this a term-and-risk caution, not a talent verdict.

69 GAMES / 3 YEARS • 50.6% TS • 0.67 AST/TO

05 WHERE DID THE MODEL IDENTIFY THE MOST SURPLUS VALUE? VISUAL 02

Contract Value by Player Trait

Average model surplus among the 10 strongest players in each profile



Profiles overlap. Salary is used as the consistent public AAV proxy.

INTERPRETATION Players were ranked separately on six traits using 2023-25 performance. Each bar shows the average model-to-salary gap among the 10 strongest comparable players in that trait; positive indicates underpayment and negative indicates overpayment.

06 ROSTER-BUILDING IMPLICATIONS GOING FORWARD

01 MAX-SALARY DISCIPLINE

Separate standard-max and supermax candidates before valuing a deal. Reserve \$1.40M slots for eligible players whose production, durability and team impact clearly justify the premium.

02 SCALABLE SKILLS

Prioritize playmaking and winning-context evidence. Those profiles each produced 7% average surplus; durable starters followed at 5%, while scoring pressure alone was roughly neutral.

03 RISK & TERM

Use shorter terms, partial guarantees or incentives when value depends on health or role growth. Treat 2026 results as monitoring evidence – not hindsight.

SOURCES: Listed 2026 salaries are from the Her Hoop Stats WNBA Salary Cap Database and are used as the only consistent public proxy for AAV because complete contract-term and AAV data were not reliably available for every player. Player production, efficiency, role, availability, team results, and playoff/championship context from 2023-25 - plus 2026 monitoring through July 18 - come from whoop's public WNBA Stats and ESPN feeds. All-Star selections come from whoop game rosters; All-WNBA, All-Defensive, and major awards from official WNBA releases; salary limits and eligibility from the 2026 WNBA CBA. Fair value is a two-model estimate trained on 133 veterans, evaluated with repeated eight-fold cross-validation and out-of-fold predictions, and capped at each comparable player's attainable standard or supermax; it is not a contract quote. Health, fit, role, term, guarantees, and negotiating leverage remain partly unobserved; early 2026 results are monitoring evidence only, not hindsight. Logos and headshots are public WNBA, team, and Wikimedia media assets.